BIHAR

MAKEOVER OF THE MANDAL CITADEL

By Amitabh Srivastava



ANI

On January 5, when Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge kickstarted the Bihar version of the Bharat Jodo Yatra in Banka, the man who arranged the logistics, and then walked beside him, was state party president Akhilesh Prasad Singh. Just a month old in office, it's Akhilesh's brief to keep the yatra alive till it culminates next month in Bodh Gaya when Rahul Gandhi is expected to address it. He's also tasked with reviving the party in the run-up to the Lok Sabha polls—an onerous job given that the Congress has been somewhat moribund in Bihar for three decades, but made partly easy by virtue of being on the right side of the ruling alliance. More to the point, Akhilesh is a Bhumihar. That the Grand Old Party has chosen a member of one of Bihar's dominant castes to lead it is not incidental—it's part of a curious cross-party trend in a state that has otherwise been a citadel of Mandal champions.

Amidst the more macro-level events that govern Indian politics, it may have escaped notice that a month ago, on December 5, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) re-elected Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh as its national president for a fresh term of three years. No one outside Bihar may have given it a thought, but Lalan, too, is a Bhumihar. A party that thrives on caste-plus politics with a Bhumihar chief? But even that would seem a lesser event if you consider that the state unit of the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), the very epitome of Mandal politics, is in the hands of Jagadanand Singh—a dyed-in-the-wool socialist and an old associate of party supremo Lalu Prasad Yadav, but a Rajput, no less.

So what exactly is happening in Bihar? The RJD and JD(U)—the two major constituents of the ruling seven-party Mahagathbandhan (MGB)—famously thrive on the support of Other Backward Classes (OBC), Extremely Backward Classes (EBC), Dalits and Muslims. Why are they, and the Congress, placing dominant caste leaders at the helm? Well, it was the RJD, known for its particularly aggressive assertion of OBC identity, that made the first apparent course correction in November 2019 when it appointed veteran Jagadanand as its Bihar unit head—the first time it has drafted a dominant caste leader to that post since its inception in 1997. Lalu's party took the decision six months after its disastrous show in the Lok Sabha election that saw it losing every seat it contested. The move apparently paid dividends a year later—the RJD emerged as the single-largest party in the November 2020 assembly polls. No wonder, RJD leader and deputy chief minister Tejashwi Yadav and Lalu have persisted with Jagadanand's leadership. Recently, when he stopped attending the RJD office for over a month after his son Sudhakar Singh was made to step down from Nitish's cabinet in October, Lalu somehow persuaded the sulking Rajput leader to resume office.

AN IRONIC INVERSION: THE BJP IS NOW THE ONLY MAJOR PARTY IN BIHAR THAT DOES NOT HAVE A DOMINANT CASTE LEADER AS ITS ORGANISATION CHIEF

The JD(U), and now the Congress, appear to have taken a leaf from the RJD's playbook in appointing leaders from the powerful elite castes. Nitish went first, in July 2021, when he chose Lalan as the JD(U)'s national chief—the first dominant caste member in that position since its birth in October 2003. In optics, that overrides having an OBC like Umesh Kushwaha as state chief. The Congress has now followed suit. In